

Occlusion Shadow

Contact shadows that ground objects in space

Occlusion shadows — also called ambient occlusion or contact shadows — are the very dark shadows that form where surfaces come together and block light from all directions. They're subtle but critical for making objects feel grounded.

KEY CONCEPTS

What Causes It

When two surfaces are very close together, all ambient light is blocked, creating a very dark, concentrated shadow. The crack under a door, the fold of an ear, the contact point where an object meets the ground — these all have occlusion shadows.

How It Differs from Cast Shadow

Cast shadows are directional (they indicate the light source). Occlusion shadows are ambient — they exist regardless of the light direction. They can coexist with cast shadows, and often the deepest part of a cast shadow near the casting object is largely occlusion.

Using It Effectively

Add occlusion shadows last, as a final darkening step. Apply them carefully to creases, contact points, and narrow gaps. Don't overdo it — a little goes a long way. Even a thin, dark line where an object meets the ground dramatically improves the feeling of solidity.

Ambient Occlusion in Context

In digital art and 3D rendering, ambient occlusion is automatically calculated. In traditional drawing, you must observe and add it manually. Look for the very darkest spots in your reference — they're often occlusion shadows.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Draw 5 objects on a table. Add only the occlusion shadows (contact points). See the difference.
2. Draw a folded piece of fabric — study the occlusion in every fold crease.
3. Copy a portrait study and identify every occlusion shadow (corners of eyes, under nose, etc.).